

Line advantage

Military thinkers from the Civil War era and modern historians call this Confederate geographic advantage “interior lines.” For example, if a straight line is drawn, connecting two points on an arc, the line is much shorter than the arc. The Confederacy, as the country defending the arc, had the advantage of “interior lines” across its territory, while the Union had to operate on “exterior lines” outside of it. First Bull Run was the first example of a larger Confederate advantage in terms of defensive positioning.

Eventually, the Union would find that the best way to overcome the Confederate advantage of interior lines was to use its superior resources to coordinate multiple and simultaneous attacks along the entire “arc” of the Confederacy’s defensive perimeter. This goal would be achieved to some extent by the Union offensives of 1864, which eventually brought the war to an end. However, as early as First Bull Run, General Winfield Scott attempted such a coordinated strategy on exterior lines when he ordered Major General Robert Patterson in the Shenandoah Valley to advance and try to prevent Johnston from moving his troops eastward from the valley to reinforce Beauregard’s units. Unfortunately for the Union side, Patterson proved to be too timid a commander for even this relatively modest objective. The Confederates made good use of the railroads to concentrate their forces at Bull Run in opposition to Brigadier General Irwin McDowell’s advance on Manassas Junction.

